

Letter of Recommendation

April 22, 2026

To Whom It May Concern:

My name is Katinka Lennemann. I am a UCLA alum and climate advocate, published in Teen Vogue for developing California climate change curriculum. My work to pass policy and establish a district sustainability committee inspired the California Youth Climate Policy Program, a rigorous program by Ten Strands and Sierra Club on coaching students to research, draft, and pass policies in their own school districts. Most recently, I have had the privilege of being Brandon Kim's mentor in this program; through his strong leadership and ability to think critically about climate change, I could not recommend him more for the USC Dornsife High School Summer Internship Program.

From the beginning of the program, Brandon exhibited the rare quality of thinking systemically about climate change solutions. I've talked with dozens of youth leaders about climate action, and this quality truly makes him stand out. For instance, his initial approach to climate change solutions was based on thinking of climate change as a carbon in/carbon out system, which led him to research carbon sequestration. Upon running into practical implementation issues at his school district, he pivoted into wildfire prevention because of its relevance to his school district in Southern California. Brandon doesn't just carry out projects for the sake of doing something; he is incredibly attuned to the relevance and impact of his work.

Throughout our meetings, he also grew progressively better at asking critical questions about where to take his campaign and its effectiveness down the line. He is a fast learner, and picked up very well on strategies of how to talk to his school district and operate within its political system. For example, he framed wildfires as not just an environmental concern but also a health concern that ties into campus operations and culture with regard to implementation: this intersectional approach is critical for writing strong policy and building supporters.

Finally, I was impressed throughout by his attention to detail and ability to research. His policy draft document had outlined previous policies passed, with notes on how they fit into the bigger picture of wildfire policy and wildfire prevention. He noted for instance that one policy passed on air quality may have limited relevance because students were mostly on Zoom during that time. His eye for the bigger picture and critically questioning the relevance will support him in doing well in this USC program. Brandon is a strong and capable leader with deep interest in environmental policy, and he would do incredibly well in this program.

Sincerely,

Katinka Lennemann

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Katinka Lennemann', with a long horizontal flourish extending to the right.